

# Northstar Customer Support Themes Q3 2026

July to September 2026

Prepared by the Northstar Customer Care and Insights teams

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Fictional data created for the MarketSignal demo.

## 1. Volume overview

Customer care handled about 86,400 contacts in the third quarter of 2026, an increase of roughly 9% on the second quarter and a little ahead of the growth in orders. Contacts were tagged by agents at the point of resolution using a theme taxonomy of seven categories. This report summarizes the theme mix, response performance and the verbatim feedback that sits behind the numbers, and closes with recommendations for product, operations and care.

Customers under 28 generated 58% of contacts, which is consistent with Gen Z's growing importance in the customer base and with its higher propensity to contact a brand through social and messaging channels. By channel, email accounted for 38% of volume, chat 29%, phone 14%, social messages 14% and in app messages 5%. Peak weeks were the back to school period in August and the week of the app release in September, when volume was about 20% above the quarterly weekly average.

A caution on interpretation. Support contacts reflect customers who bother to get in touch, which skews toward people with a problem to solve and under represents those who quietly return an item or switch brands. The figures below are therefore best read as a guide to the friction in the customer experience, not as a measure of overall satisfaction. Where possible we compare with product returns and survey data.

## 2. Theme breakdown

The table shows the share of contacts by theme for customers under 28 and for customers aged 28 and older. Shares sum to 100% in each column.

### Theme | Under 28 | 28 and older

Sizing and fit | 31% | 22%

Product quality | 17% | 15%

Delivery and order status | 19% | 21%

Returns policy | 14% | 17%

Sustainability questions | 4% | 6%

App issues | 8% | 9%

Other | 7% | 10%

### 2.1 Sizing and fit

Sizing and fit questions accounted for 31% of all Q3 support contacts from customers under 28. The corresponding figure for older customers is noticeably lower. Most contacts are pre purchase questions asking how a style compares with another Northstar item the customer already owns, followed by post purchase requests for an exchange because the first size did not work. Agents report that the most common comparisons are between leggings and tees, joggers and hoodies, and running and court footwear. The trail shoe that runs small is the single most frequently mentioned style by name. This theme confirms the picture from the May survey and the product returns data: inconsistency across categories is what drives uncertainty, rather than a general problem with any single product.

## **2.2 Product quality**

Product quality contacts were dominated by one issue. Complaints about knit upper wear on the Knit Runner 2 rose to 1,140 tickets in Q3, most citing fraying near the toe flex point within 90 days. Customers describe the upper wearing through earlier than they expected for a shoe at this price, often after regular walking and commuting rather than hard training. Ticket volume understates the problem, because the returns data show a larger number of durability returns that never generated a contact. Agents also report that, before September, frontline guidance classified early fraying as normal wear unless the customer could show a manufacturing defect, which produced frustration and a number of repeat contacts. Guidance was changed in late September to treat early toe fraying as a product issue eligible for replacement or refund. Other quality themes, such as pilling on leggings and zipper failures on outerwear, were small by comparison.

## **2.3 Delivery and order status**

Delivery and order status was the second largest theme overall. Typical contacts asked for tracking updates, reported delays and asked about split shipments. Orders from the personalization pilot stood out. Personalized orders were 2.4 times more likely than standard orders to generate a where is my order ticket. Made to order pairs took an average of 12 days to arrive, customers could not see production milestones in the tracker, and agents had few answers to give beyond the original estimate. Standard orders were comparatively stable, with delays concentrated in the August peak. Younger customers told us they expect delivery in a matter of days and are prepared to contact the brand quickly when an order falls behind that expectation.

## **2.4 Returns policy**

Returns policy contacts concentrate on three questions: how long the return window is, whether worn footwear can be returned, and what happens to personalized items, which carried exchange only terms during the pilot. Customers frequently compare our terms with those of a value competitor that advertises free returns within 60 days. Older customers contact us about returns policy slightly more often than younger customers, who tend to treat returns as routine and to ask about exchanges and size swaps instead.

## **2.5 Sustainability questions**

Sustainability questions are a small share of volume but a revealing one. Customers ask where products are made, what proportion of a fabric is recycled, and what a claim on a hang tag actually means. Several describe checking the product page, finding only a general statement, and writing to

ask for the specifics. The questions are consistent with survey feedback asking for plain facts about recycled content and factory locations rather than icons. They are also relatively easy to resolve with better product page information.

## 2.6 App issues

App contacts rose after the September release. The main themes were crashes in the size selector, failure to apply saved payment methods and delays before orders appeared in the order history. App related contacts are a modest share of the total, but they are concentrated among younger customers and among the most engaged customers who buy through the app, who also have the highest average order values.

## 3. Channel response times

Response performance varied widely by channel, and the widest gap was on social. Median first response time on social channels slipped to 9.5 hours in Q3 against a service target of 4 hours. The shortfall reflects staffing arrangements in which social messages were handled by a small team during business hours, with no weekend cover. Customers who message through social platforms tend to expect conversational replies within hours, and a number of contacts in this channel were escalated from comments on posts.

### **Channel | Median first response | Service target**

Social messages | 9.5 hours | 4 hours

Email | 7.8 hours | 12 hours

Chat | 1.8 minutes | 2 minutes

Phone | 3.5 minutes wait | 3 minutes

Email and chat met their targets, with chat just inside the threshold even in peak weeks. Phone slightly missed its target in August. Social is the one channel where performance is clearly below the standard that customers expect, and it is also the channel where Gen Z customers and Social Shop buyers are most likely to turn first.

## 4. What customers said

The following examples are paraphrased from contact notes and are representative of recurring themes.

- A student customer said she bought the same size of tee and leggings, found the tee much roomier, and had to pay attention to which categories to size up in.
- A customer who bought the Knit Runner 2 for commuting said the toe area frayed in under three months, that the agent suggested it was normal wear, and that she had now switched to a different brand.
- A buyer of a personalized pair asked for an update on day nine and was told only that production was in progress, and said the lack of status was more frustrating than the delay itself.
- A customer asked why the product page for a jacket said made with recycled materials without saying how much, and asked for a figure.

- A customer who updated the app could no longer open the size guide from the product page and ended up ordering two sizes.

## 5. Recommendations

We suggest five actions for the coming quarter, in rough order of importance.

- Extend social cover. Add weekend and evening coverage for social messages and set a target of first response within 4 hours at the median.
- Support the fit program. Provide care with a cross category size comparison tool and capture structured fit reasons on every exchange to feed product and merchandising.
- Close the loop on durability. Route wear complaints directly to product quality, track the toe fraying rate weekly, and communicate the new replacement policy clearly.
- Make order status visible. Add production milestones to the tracker for made to order items and send proactive updates when an order passes its estimate.
- Publish materials facts. Add recycled content and production country to every product page, and give agents a short script for sustainability questions in the interim.

Customer care will report progress against these actions in the Q4 review, using the same theme taxonomy so that results remain comparable.